

CHICORY *Cichorium intybus*

A highly ornamental plant, there are three distinct, attractive types of chicory: Witloof or Belgian, which has elongated heads of tight, white leaves, and is usually forced and blanched; radicchio or red chicory, which has tight heads of crisp, red leaves, similar in appearance to a small lettuce; and sugarloaf, which has looser, green leaves. All types have a decidedly bitter taste, but can be eaten raw in salad, or cooked.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Chicory is a very tolerant crop, and will grow well even in poor soils and partial shade. It is best not to sow seed too early or plants might bolt, so begin in late spring and sow through to midsummer.

Sow seed directly into the ground at a depth of .5 in (1 cm). Once seedlings develop, thin Witloof chicory to leave about 9 in (23 cm) space between plants, and about 12 in (30 cm) between radicchio or sugarloaf types, as these will develop larger heads.

CROP CARE

Ensure that chicory crops are kept weeded and well-watered to discourage them from bolting. Protect with cold frames or cloches if frosts are forecast.



A large box is ideal for forcing.

HARVESTING

Chicory is usually ready to harvest in a month, once heads are firm. Raddichio or sugarloaf types will store once lifted, or they can be left in the ground for longer if not immediately needed. Dig up Witloof types and force (see above). Once chicons (Belgian endives) have been cut, recover the stumps—you may get a second crop.